

Ostriches

A bird that can't fly, and roams where there is very little cover, has to run fast to escape predators. The flightless ostrich does just that. As well as being the world's biggest bird it is the fastest animal on two legs. There are two species and both live in open habitats in Africa.

Ostrich chicks

All female ostriches in the group lay their eggs in a communal nest, so adults may end up guarding large crèches of chicks.

Somali ostrich

This species lives in the eastern horn of Africa—in Somalia, Ethiopia, and Kenya. Males have a gray head, neck, legs, and feet, and a deeper black plumage than the common ostrich.

Masai region

In the Masai region of east Africa, common ostriches have a reddish-tinge to their neck but are more closely related to the gray-necked ostriches further south.

Rift Valley

The two species of ostrich are separated by the Great Rift Valley (pictured below). On the eastern side, the Somali ostrich has split away from common ostriches and evolved into a separate species.



Desert dweller

In the southernmost part of their range, common ostriches live in hot, dry desert.

Kalahari Desert

Namib Desert

MALE OSTRICHES
STAND UP TO
9 FT (2.7 M) TALL

AT TOP SPEED AN OSTRICH CAN RUN
ABOUT 43 MPH (70 KPH)—THAT'S
FASTER THAN A RACEHORSE